

END OF SPYCRAFT
US Navy sailors recover a high-altitude surveillance balloon (inset), allegedly deployed by China, after it was shot down off the coast of South Carolina, Feb. 5

AP

CHINA'S EYES IN THE SKY

- Per US intelligence, Chinese 'spy balloons' of the type shot down over the US conduct surveillance from the upper atmosphere at altitudes above where commercial jets fly—between 60,000 ft and 80,000 ft, or higher
- Part of a vast surveillance programme of the People's Liberation Army, they have flown across five continents and collected information on military assets of countries like India, Japan, Taiwan and the Philippines
- Equipped with a detection and fight function, they can provide earth space communication relay functions to ground operations personnel infiltrating into any country
- Provided with EMP (electro-magnetic pulse) jamming capability
- The six entities the US has banned for alleged links to Beijing's spy balloon programme are: Beijing Nanjiang Aerospace Technology Co., China Electronics Technology Group Corp, Dongguan Lingkong Remote Sensing Technology Co., Eagles Men Aviation Science & Technology Group, Guangzhou Tian-Hai-Xiang Aviation Technology Co., Shanxi Eagles Men Aviation Science & Technology Group

works. In 2020, Hikvision had won a tender from the Delhi government to install 150,000 CCTV cameras in the national capital. It is also listed as a vendor by Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), which works on highly sensitive and classified defence projects. More worryingly, the same firm has also supplied cameras to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and the Special Protection Group (SPG), which is responsible for the security of the prime minister. Its surveillance cameras are being extensively used in military establishments.

Hikvision and Dahua are, in fact, at the very centre of the suspicion of espionage circling around Chinese surveillance devices. The internal note by the MoD identified Hikvision as having 41 per cent Chinese government holding and noted that it operates in India in collaboration with an Indian company. "The modules of these cameras systems are supplied by the Chinese firm; however, these products are marketed as 'Made in India'," says the MoD letter. It added that loss of data could be through programmed/ coded servers or embedded hardware for wi-fi or SIM-based connectivity or, during maintenance or replacement, culled from the memory/ cache of the surveillance system.

INDIA TODAY contacted Prama Hikvision and Dahua Technology India Private Limited—the Indian subsidiaries of Hikvision and Dahua—for their comments. While Prama Hikvision hasn't responded, Dahua in its response said, "As a private sector business, we are neither owned nor controlled by any government. Dahua takes its compliance